Preparing the home for an earthquake and structural safety

Preparing the home for an earthquake is essential for protecting lives and reducing risks. Although earthquakes cannot be prevented, measures taken in advance can lessen the negative effects and can save lives.

1. Structural safety of the building

When you buy or live in an apartment, it is important to check the structure of the building:

- **Type of construction:** Buildings made of reinforced concrete or well-designed metal structures resist earthquakes better than plain masonry.
- **Age of the building:** Apartment blocks built before 1977 — before the modern seismic standards — present a higher risk.
- **Foundation and walls:** A solid foundation and properly connected load-bearing walls ensure stability.
- **Seismic risk class:** Avoid buildings with a high seismic risk (e.g. class I).

- **Building plan:** Regular, symmetrical structures with an even distribution of load are more stable.
- **Area:** Avoid unstable land, areas prone to landslides or areas with a risk of flooding.

2. Securing furniture and objects

Heavy furniture, such as wardrobes, bookcases or large household appliances, should be fixed to the walls in order to prevent it from tipping over during an earthquake. Fragile or heavy objects should be placed in safe spots, preferably on lower shelves. These simple measures reduce the risk of accidents in the home.

3. Checking the utilities

The gas, water and electricity systems should be checked and maintained. During an earthquake they can cause fires, explosions or floods. It is essential for every member of the family to know how to quickly shut off the utilities in case of emergency.

4. Evacuation and shelter plan

It is important to set up a plan of action within the family. Family members must know where to take shelter during the earthquake and how to act afterwards. Communication and preparation in advance can make the difference between safety and danger.

5. Risk assessment before purchase

Before buying an apartment, it is useful to ask for:

- a structural-expertise report or a certificate of seismic resistance
- the history of repairs or strengthening work on the building
- information about the materials used and the quality of the construction work

These checks help you choose a safer home and reduce the risks in the event of an earthquake.